



Instagram: "We don't spy"

The head of Instagram stated firmly that they do not snoop on their users as part of their ad targeting strategy. <https://digit.in/july19-78>



Startup Drive.ai closing down

The autonomous vehicle startup is shutting down after 4 years, despite being valued at \$200 million. <https://digit.in/july19-79>

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everyone produces data, voluntarily or otherwise. In a country like India, the production of data is

inevitable. For the ever-curious journalist, making sense of a population of 1.2 billion, close to 800 languages, an electorate of 814 million and the largest urban agglomeration across the world can be facilitated by a little something we call data. Data needs to be reported to produce meaningful, contextual stories, that's where investigative data journalists come in. Still, there appears to be a shroud of mystery around this profession and people often have misconceptions about the exact nature of this career and what it entails. Let's delve into the arduous, but rewarding world of investigative data journalism.

WHAT IS INVESTIGATIVE DATA JOURNALISM?

Investigative data journalism quite literally means investigating data to derive stories. The methodical and academic study of a certain subject is taken up, where journalists examine data and documents and discuss topics or reach conclusions through an academic lens. Data, be it numerical or textual data, is accessed by journalists and computational methods are applied to make sense of it. According to Srinivasan Ramani, Associate Editor of the Hindu, who has dabbled extensively in data journalism, "Investigative data journalism is a subset of investigative journalism that uses data as a base to provide reporting, analysis and conclusions". There are essentially three steps – data mining/scraping, data preparation and then analysis and visualisation. A full-rounded investigative data report also includes ground reporting to validate the data analysis. The only difference between investigative data journalism and traditional journalism is that the latter mostly relies on human sources like insiders, experts, scholars, and scientists while data journalism treats data as the ultimate source. Siddharthya Roy, Pulitzer Crisis Reporting Grantee and data journalist at the Diplomat,



Investigative Data Journalism

More than just numbers...

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reveals, "Investigative data journalism is not access-based journalism". Meaning it doesn't rely on sources as heavily as traditional journalism does.

SKILLS REQUIRED

Data stories are still stories. Therefore, someone who wants to make this profession their full-time career (or even part-time) must first and foremost, have the drive, curiosity and tenacity that journalists possess, along with the ability to write and weave a story. Roy states, "Aspirants must possess three skills to enter this field – you need to have copious amounts of curiosity, you need to not be 'tech-averse', so basically you should be willing to reskill yourself and pick up techniques and knowledge quickly, and lastly you must be a good, tenacious journalist". Contradictory to popular belief, data journalists believe that you don't necessarily need to have

an engineering, science, or math background. As long as you are an individual who can think logically, know how to use spreadsheets (this is a must – yes) and have a journalists' persistence and curiosity, you can enter this field. Knowing how to code is an advantage though. Ramani's opinions do somewhat mirror Roy's since he believes, "An investigative data journalist must have technical abilities – sorting, cleaning, interpreting data and creating visualisations (all of which can be done on Excel), must have the patience to sort through large datasets, and must possess domain expertise to piece data together and interpret it properly".

PROCESS OF REPORTING AN INVESTIGATIVE DATA STORY

The first and foremost step in reporting an investigative data story is gathering the data itself. Data can be generated from private or public organisations,